an incredulous shake of heads by those lower down the chain of command. It hardly mattered, though, for it seemed nobody at the top was listening anyway.

Kaul as the QMG, as we have seen, allocated quotas as he pleased without any real understanding of ground realities. General S. D. Verma, the XV Corps commander, tried reason with Bogey Sen, but the CGS made it amply clear that he was not likely to rock the boat. Verma was equally adamant and demanded to know how he could achieve anything in the way of operational readiness since the airlift tonnage allotted by the QMG barely allowed for the maintenance of existing garrisons. After allowing for survival loads, there was no room for weapons and ammunition, let alone additional troops. When Military Operations was confronted with this unpleasant math, they didn't seem unduly perturbed as 'the Chinese were not likely to start a war'. As a result, it was impossible for XV Corps to have any overall strategic or tactical plan. All they could think of at that stage was to set up a few lightly armed air-supplied posts, and then somehow keep those men alive.

In February 1961, the prime minister in a statement to the Lok Sabha implied that the army could take on the Chinese in Ladakh: 'The situation has broadly changed in our favour, not as much as we want it, but is a fact that in areas which they have occupied progressively, the situation has been changing from the military point of view and other points of view, in our favour.'

This was pure wishful thinking and bore no resemblance to the actual situation on the ground. A lesser man would have kept quiet for it was never easy to contradict Nehru, yet Verma protested to Thapar, his immediate boss in the chain of command. In a strongly worded letter, he said that the prime minister's remarks were optimistic and misleading and that his letter should be placed on record with Army HQ. By then, Thapar must have had enough indications to know that it was he, and not Thorat, who was slated to take over the army from Thimayya. Not surprisingly, the Western Army Commander refused to endorse his corps commander's views. On the contrary, he tried to get Verma to withdraw his letter saying the situation in Ladakh was well known and the prime minister's remarks were only meant for the general public. Verma refused to withdraw his letter. Thapar then made sure that the letter did not reach Nehru, the only man who mattered in the eventual analysis. Why antagonize the man?